

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Note something specific -> Reference it later -> No agenda — just showing you listened

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

In your next conversation, pick one specific thing the person says and reference it later — even just five minutes later. Nothing more.

BEST FOR

- Building rapport and trust over time
- Making people feel genuinely heard in meetings
- Networking conversations and relationship maintenance
- One-on-one check-ins and informal catch-ups

PHRASE BANK

Recall Openers · Referencing what they said

- "You mentioned earlier that..."
- "Going back to what you said about..."
- "That thing you said about X — I have been thinking about it."
- "I remembered you said... — how did that go?"
- "Last time we spoke, you mentioned... Any update on that?"
- "You brought up X in passing — I wanted to ask more about it."
- "I did not forget what you said about... I wanted to come back to it."
- "That point you made about X stuck with me."

Warmth Signals · Making the reference feel natural

- "I am asking because it sounded important, not just making conversation."
- "That came up again in my thinking after we spoke."
- "I thought about that on the way home."
- "It was a throwaway comment but it actually landed with me."
- "I wanted to circle back — not to push, just to hear more."
- "Only if you want to say more about it."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Generic 'How are things?' with no memory of past conversations
Better: How have you been?
Best: Last time we spoke you mentioned X — how did that turn out?
- Weak: Bringing up a reference in a way that feels like an agenda
Better: I remembered you were dealing with X.
Best: Casual reference with genuine curiosity and no expectation.
- Weak: Forgetting entirely and pretending you remember
Better: I think you mentioned something about...
Best: Honest admission: 'I cannot remember the exact detail but I know it was important.'

DECISION TREE

If Someone mentions something personal or important in passing

Note it mentally. Reference it later or in the next conversation.

"You mentioned X earlier — I wanted to come back to that."

If You have forgotten the detail but want to show you remember

Acknowledge the approximate memory honestly.

"You mentioned something about your project last week — I cannot remember the detail, but I wanted to ask how it went."

If The follow-up topic might be sensitive

Soften the reference with an opt-out.

"Only if you want to share — I just remembered you mentioned X."

If You are at the start of a meeting or conversation

Open with a reference before any agenda.

"Before we start — you mentioned last time that... Any update?"

SCENARIOS

Meeting follow-up: reconnecting after a week

Open with something specific they said last time. — "Last week you mentioned the deadline was tight — did that resolve?"

Networking event: second conversation with someone

Reference one specific thing from the first conversation. — "You mentioned you were weighing two options — did you land on one?"

Manager check-in: showing you remember context

Reference something they mentioned in passing previously. — "You said something last month about the team dynamics shifting — I wanted to check in on that."

Friend or partner: after a difficult conversation

Reference what they shared and show it stayed with you. — "You mentioned that thing with your family — I have been thinking about it."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When referencing something the person has clearly moved on from or would rather forget.
- When you do not genuinely remember — do not fake specificity, it will be detected.
- When the reference could feel like surveillance or scorekeeping rather than genuine care.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Noticing

In one conversation today, consciously note one specific thing the other person says — even if you do not reference it yet.

Day 2 — Same-session reference

In one conversation, reference something the person said earlier in the same conversation.

Day 3 — Next-day recall

Follow up with one person about something they mentioned yesterday.

Day 4 — The specific detail

Practice making your reference specific. Not 'you mentioned work' but 'you mentioned the Tuesday deadline.'

Day 5 — Natural timing

Find the right moment to reference — not forced in, but when it fits the conversation flow.

Day 6 — Longer memory

Reference something from a conversation two or more weeks ago.

Day 7 — Calibration

Notice: did your references feel genuine? Did people open up? Were any references too intrusive?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I actually listen rather than wait for my turn to speak?
- Did I note something specific — not just a general topic?

- Did I reference it at a natural point rather than forcing it in?
- Did I reference it out of genuine interest, not as a technique?
- Did I give the other person space to say more or deflect?
- Did the reference feel warm and personal — not transactional?
- Did I avoid using the recall as leverage or manipulation?